THEN VS NOW

THE SALESMAN'S BLUEPRINT

Timeless Selling Principles, Rebuilt for the Internet Age



GETFREEEBOOKS

Contents

The Salesman's Blueprint

- A Note from the Publisher
- Copyright
- Acknowledgements
- Quick Start Summary
- Chapter 1: Know What You Sell
- Chapter 2: Understand the Buyer's Mind
- Chapter 3: Make the First Impression Count
- Chapter 4: Welcome Objections
- Chapter 5: Believe in It First
- Chapter 6: Sell Through Service
- Chapter 7: Follow Up
- Conclusion: Old Rules, New Screens
- Your Action Plan
- Glossary
- Sources & Notes
- About the Publisher
- More Free Ebooks

THE SALESMAN'S BLUEPRINT

Timeless Selling Principles, Rebuilt for the Internet Age

Seven classic principles of salesmanship, quoted from the originals and rebuilt for the internet.

GetFreeEbooks

First published 2026

Website: GetFreeEbooks.com

A Note from the Publisher

The travelling salesman of the early twentieth century had no analytics dashboard, no CRM and no retargeting pixel. What he had was a train timetable, a sample case and a door that might or might not open. To survive he had to understand people — what they wanted, what they feared, and what would make them say yes.

The writers collected here turned that hard-won understanding into books. Each chapter takes one of their principles, lets a writer from the early twentieth century explain it in their own words, and then translates it into the language of online selling: sales pages, discovery calls, email sequences and customer success.

— GetFreeEbooks.com

Copyright

The Salesman's Blueprint © 2026 GetFreeEbooks. Commentary, arrangement and modern notes © 2026 GetFreeEbooks.

Quoted historical passages are taken from public domain works credited in the Sources & Notes section. This book is for general information and education; it is not legal, financial or professional advice.

Published by GetFreeEbooks

GetFreeEbooks.com

First Edition, 2026

A note on process: this book was assembled with offline software from public domain source material, then reviewed before publication.

Acknowledgements

Thank you to the generations of writers, editors and volunteers who kept these works alive long enough for them to reach the public domain — and to everyone who digitised, proofread and preserved them since.

This book is published through GetFreeEbooks, a platform built on a simple idea: that good books should be easy to find, and free to read. Thank you to that community of readers and writers for giving books like this one a place to land.

Quick Start Summary

Each chapter in this book takes one principle from the old masters of selling and advertising, quotes them in their own words, and translates the idea for the internet. Here is the whole book at a glance:

- **Know What You Sell** — If a customer could ask it, your page should already answer it. *(Still true — use it as written)*
- **Understand the Buyer's Mind** — Find out why they buy before you decide what to say. *(Still true — use it as written)*
- **Make the First Impression Count** — Treat your first screen like a first handshake: clean, confident and about them. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*
- **Welcome Objections** — Every objection you hear twice deserves a permanent answer on your page. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*
- **Believe in It First** — Sell only what you would buy, and let the reader see why you believe in it. *(Still true — use it as written)*
- **Sell Through Service** — Your best next customer is usually one you already have — look after them. *(More important now than it was then)*
- **Follow Up** — Lead with your strongest argument, then follow up — politely, with permission, and with something new each time. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*

Chapter 1: Know What You Sell

No seller could sell what he did not understand, the old manuals insisted, whether he worked across a counter, on the road or by letter. Knowledge of the goods came before charm, before technique, before everything. William Walker Atkinson described it this way in *The Psychology of Salesmanship* (1912):

> *In the first place, an important part of the Pre-Approach is a correct and complete knowledge of your goods. Too many men rush to the Approach without knowing what they have to sell. It is not enough to know brands and prices—one should know his goods from top to bottom, inside and outside, from the raw material to the finished article. He should feel perfectly at home with his goods, so that he may have full information regarding them on tap, and thus have his mind free for the strategy of the sale. A little close, earnest intelligent study of one's line of goods will not only supply one with an efficient weapon, but will also impart to him a sense of certainty and confidence that he cannot have otherwise. What would be thought of a teacher of natural history who did not understand animals? And yet many salesmen are equally as ignorant about their subject.*
>
> *— William Walker Atkinson, The Psychology of Salesmanship (1912)*

What It Means Now

Online, product knowledge shows up as clarity. The pages that convert answer the questions a buyer would have asked a well-informed salesperson: what exactly it does, who it is for, who it is not for, and what happens after purchase.

It also shows up in support. A founder or team who understand the product deeply write better documentation, better FAQs and better emails — and customers can tell the difference within a sentence.

Then	Now
Studying the line	Detailed product pages and documentation
Answering the customer's questions	FAQ sections and help centres
Demonstrating the goods	Demos, walkthrough videos, free trials

In Practice: Answer on a product FAQ

Before: Please contact us for more details.

After: The frame is solid oak, 72 cm tall, and ships flat. Assembly takes about twenty minutes

with the key in the box.

Every “contact us for details” is a customer who has to do extra work before buying, and many won’t.

The Verdict: Still true — use it as written

This is one of the principles that has come through the century untouched. The channel is new; the advice is not.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *If a customer could ask it, your page should already answer it.*

Try This

- List the ten questions customers ask most and make sure each is answered on the page
- Add a ‘who this is not for’ line to your offer
- Record a short walkthrough of the product in use

Chapter 2: Understand the Buyer's Mind

The early writers on salesmanship tried to map the mind of the buyer: the motives, moods and mental states that lead from indifference to decision. Here is how William Walker Atkinson put it in *The Psychology of Salesmanship* (1912):

> *In the Psychology of Salesmanship there are two important elements, viz: (1) The Mind of the Salesman; and (2) the Mind of the Buyer. The proposition, or the goods to be sold, constitute the connecting link between the two Minds, or the common point upon which the two Minds must unite, blend, and come to agreement. The Sale itself is the result of the fusion and agreement of the two Minds—the product of the action and reaction between them.*
>
> *— William Walker Atkinson, The Psychology of Salesmanship (1912)*

What It Means Now

Their vocabulary of 'suggestion' and 'mental states' belongs to its period, but the practical instinct was sound: people buy for their own reasons, and the seller's first job is to find out what they are. Discovery calls, customer interviews and on-site surveys are the modern tools.

The best online marketers still spend more time listening than writing. Reviews of competitors, support tickets and forum threads are a free window into the buyer's mind — the same window the travelling salesman opened by asking questions at the counter.

Then	Now
Studying the buyer's motives	Customer research and interviews
Reading the prospect's manner	Behaviour analytics and heatmaps
Adapting the talk to the man	Segmented emails and personalised offers

In Practice: Question in a customer survey

Before: How satisfied are you with our product?

After: What were you trying to get done when you first searched for something like us?

The first question measures a mood. The second tells you why people buy, in their own words, which is the raw material for every page you write next.

The Verdict: Still true — use it as written

A century of new media has not dented this one. It was sound advice then, and it is sound advice now.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Find out why they buy before you decide what to say.*

Try This

- Interview five recent customers about the moment they decided to buy
- Read twenty competitor reviews and note the recurring complaints
- Write your offer using the buyer's words, not yours

Chapter 3: Make the First Impression Count

The old manuals devoted whole chapters to the approach: how the salesman entered the room, how he carried himself, and how he (or the letter sent in his place) opened in the first vital moments. In *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911), the writer (whose name the book does not give) put it like this:

> *The letter that is sent out unaided to make its own approach, open its own canvass and either complete a sale or pave the way to a sale may be called "the original sales letter." There has been no inquiry, no preliminary introduction of any kind. The letter is simply the substitute for the salesman who voluntarily seeks out his own prospect, presents his proposition and tries to land an order.*
>
> *— Business Correspondence, Vol. 1 (1911)*

What It Means Now

Your approach now happens without you. It is the first screen of your website, your profile photo, the preview text of your email and the first ten seconds of your video. Visitors often form an impression before they have read a word, and it colours how they read everything that follows.

The old advice translates directly: be clean, be clear, be relevant to the person in front of you. A slow, cluttered or generic first screen is the equivalent of arriving at a customer's office with mud on your boots.

Then	Now
The salesman's appearance	Website design and load speed
The opening sentence	Email preview text and video intro
The calling card	Profile, bio and About page

In Practice: Top of a homepage on a phone

Before: A slow slideshow of the office, the logo, and a menu of nine items.

After: One sentence saying what you do and for whom, and one button, all visible before the reader scrolls.

Visitors decide whether to stay before they reach anything you are proud of further down. Put the answer to "am I in the right place?" first.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

The goal is the same as it ever was; only the route to the customer has changed.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Treat your first screen like a first handshake: clean, confident and about them.*

Try This

- Check your homepage loads quickly on a phone
- Rewrite your email preview text for your next send
- Ask someone unfamiliar with your business what they think you do after five seconds

Chapter 4: Welcome Objections

A good salesman, the old writers said, prepares for objections instead of fearing them. An objection is a question in disguise, and a question can be answered. Writing in *Certain Success* (1920), Norval A. Hawkins observed:

> *I know a salesman who trained himself in resourcefulness by typing on about fifty cards all the objections to his goods or proposition that he could imagine. For ten or fifteen minutes every evening he played solitaire with these cards. He would shuffle them, held face down, and then deal off, face up, objection after objection. He never could tell which was coming next. In a few weeks he had trained himself to give an answer instantly to each objection, and to utilize it as a help instead of a hindrance in his selling. Thereafter opposition and criticism from prospects had no terrors for this salesman. He was able to get rid of objections so swiftly, surely, and completely that they never had time to grow formidable in the mind of the other man.*
>
> *— Norval A. Hawkins, Certain Success (1920)*

What It Means Now

On a sales page there is no one to answer the objection aloud, so the page must answer it in advance. That is the real purpose of FAQs, comparison tables, guarantees and 'is this right for me?' sections.

Live chat, comment sections and sales calls let you hear objections in real time. Collect them. Every objection you hear twice belongs on the page.

Then	Now
Answering at the counter	FAQs and objection-handling sections
'It costs too much'	Value framing and pricing comparisons
'I'll think it over'	Guarantees, trials and follow-up emails

In Practice: Handling "it's too expensive"

Before: Defensive replies in comment threads, one argument at a time.

After: A plain FAQ entry beside the price: "Why does this cost more than the budget options?", answered with what the extra money actually buys.

An objection you hear every week deserves a permanent, public answer where the doubt arises, not a private one after it has cost you the sale.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

The idea survives intact; only the tools have changed. Use the modern channel, but keep the old discipline.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Every objection you hear twice deserves a permanent answer on your page.*

Try This

- Keep a running list of every objection prospects raise
- Turn the top five into FAQ entries
- Add a comparison with the alternative your buyer is most likely considering

Chapter 5: Believe in It First

Enthusiasm, the old writers insisted, is contagious — and so is its absence. A salesman who does not believe in his goods cannot make anyone else believe in them. As William Walker Atkinson explained in *The Psychology of Salesmanship* (1912):

> *The essence of this stage of the demonstration is that it should be given in the spirit of a conversational recital of an interesting story, or description of an event. Speak in an impersonal way; that is, avoid suggesting to the prospect that you are trying to sell him the thing. Let this part of your talk be given from the sheer enthusiasm inspired in your mind by the merits of your proposition. Let it be a labor of love—forget all about your hope of sale or profit. Your one aim and object of life, at that moment, should be that of inspiring the prospect with the wonderful merits of your proposition, which you yourself entertain. Yours should be the spirit of the propogandist seeking converts—imparting information for the good of others, and "for the cause." Forget the forthcoming collection plate, in the earnestness of your sermon.*
>
> *— William Walker Atkinson, The Psychology of Salesmanship (1912)*

What It Means Now

The modern version is authenticity. Audiences have become very good at detecting copy written by people who do not care, and founder-led marketing works partly because genuine belief is hard to fake.

The caution is the same as it always was: enthusiasm is not evidence. The strongest online marketing pairs real conviction with real proof, so the reader can share the belief without having to take it on trust.

Then	Now
The salesman's conviction	Founder stories and behind-the-scenes content
Sincerity in the letter	Authentic brand voice
Faith in the goods	Using and showing your own product

In Practice: Recommendation in a newsletter

Before: This is simply the best planner on the market!

After: I've used this planner every day for three years. The one thing I'd change is the cover, which scuffs within a month.

Superlatives sound like selling. Long use and an honest flaw sound like belief, and they are far

more persuasive.

The Verdict: Still true — use it as written

Nothing essential has changed here. Move the advice onto a screen and it can be followed almost word for word.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Sell only what you would buy, and let the reader see why you believe in it.*

Try This

- Write one paragraph on why you personally use or trust your product
- Share a behind-the-scenes post about how it is made
- Remove any claim you are not genuinely convinced of

Chapter 6: Sell Through Service

The best of the old salesmen understood that the first sale is the beginning, not the end. What brought a customer back was service after the order: asking whether the goods had satisfied, and putting right what had not. Norval A. Hawkins made the point in *Certain Success* (1920):

> *Few salesmen know what sales service is, and how it should be rendered. Service is the very soul of the certain success selling process. Service must be studied as a purpose until the principles underlying the fullest satisfaction of the buyer's real needs are mastered, and all false misconceptions of service are cleared away from the salesman's idea of his obligation to the purchaser of his goods of sale.*
>
> *— Norval A. Hawkins, Certain Success (1920)*

What It Means Now

Online businesses call it retention, lifetime value and customer success. Acquiring a new customer is usually far more expensive than keeping an existing one, and subscription models have made the relationship after the sale the whole business.

Onboarding emails, helpful documentation, fast support and genuine follow-up are the modern equivalents of the salesman who called back to make sure the goods were giving satisfaction.

Then	Now
Calling back after the sale	Onboarding and check-in emails
Goodwill	Reviews, referrals and community
The repeat order	Subscriptions, renewals and upsells

In Practice: The week after a purchase

Before: Silence, then a sales email a month later.

After: Day three: "Did it arrive in one piece? Reply to this email if anything's wrong and we'll put it right."

The second email costs nothing to send and is the cheapest way there is to turn a first order into a second one.

The Verdict: More important now than it was then

If anything, this matters more online than it ever did on paper. The internet has raised both the

rewards for getting it right and the penalties for getting it wrong.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Your best next customer is usually one you already have — look after them.*

Try This

- Set up a simple welcome sequence for new customers
- A week after each purchase, ask the customer one question: 'Is it working for you?'
- Make it easy to refer a friend

Chapter 7: Follow Up

The sales correspondents of the early twentieth century built whole systems of follow-up letters — and, unusually for their time, they measured them. What they learned was that follow-up pays, but only when the first contact carries your best argument. Here is how the anonymous author of *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911) put it:

> *Experiments show that the interest of an inquirer wanes rapidly after the receipt of the first response. In replying to inquiries, the chance of securing a sale with a third letter is much less than the chance with the first, for after receiving the first letter, if it is unconvincing, the inquirer is likely to come to an adverse decision that cannot afterwards be easily changed. In this respect, answers to inquirers are much like unsolicited letters sent out to non-inquirers and planned to create and build up interest. In a number of lines of business the third letter sent out in response to an inquiry barely pays for itself. For this reason, it is usually poor policy in handling this class of business to withhold some strong argument from the first letter in order to save it for the second or the third. Better fire the 13-inch gun as soon as you have the range.*
>
> *— Business Correspondence, Vol. 1 (1911)*

What It Means Now

Follow-up now happens by email sequence, retargeting and CRM reminders. Many buyers are not ready the first time they see an offer, and a well-designed sequence keeps you present until they are.

The limit is respect. Spam laws, unsubscribe rules and simple courtesy mean that modern persistence must be permission-based and easy to escape. The old salesman who would not leave the doorstep would be blocked today.

Then	Now
The second and third call	Email follow-up sequences
The salesman's call book	CRM reminders and pipelines
Reminding the customer	Retargeting ads

In Practice: A follow-up sequence

Before: Five emails, each saying some version of "Just checking in!"

After: Five emails, each bringing something new: a short case study, an answer to a common question, and finally a real deadline.

Follow-up works when every message earns its place. The strongest argument still goes first; later messages add, rather than repeat.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

Keep the thinking and update the equipment: the tools of the period have been replaced, but the reasoning behind them has not.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Lead with your strongest argument, then follow up — politely, with permission, and with something new each time.*

Try This

- Write a three-email follow-up for people who showed interest but did not buy
- Set a CRM reminder for every open conversation
- Make unsubscribing one click

Conclusion: Old Rules, New Screens

Of the seven principles in this book, three have survived untouched, three still hold but have moved to new channels and one matters more now than it did then. That is a remarkable record for advice written before the first website, the first search engine or the first social feed.

The reason is simple. The media have changed beyond recognition, but the people at the other end of them have not. They are still busy, still sceptical, still looking for something that will make their lives a little better — and still willing to stop for a moment when someone speaks to them clearly, honestly and about the thing they care about.

The writers quoted here learned that lesson one printed page at a time, with every word paid for. You can learn it faster, and test it more cheaply, than any of them could have dreamed. Start with one principle, one page and one change this week. Then come back for the next.

Your Action Plan

Work through one chapter a week. Each list below is small enough to finish in an afternoon, and each item produces something you can measure.

Week 1: Know What You Sell

- List the ten questions customers ask most and make sure each is answered on the page
- Add a ‘who this is not for’ line to your offer
- Record a short walkthrough of the product in use

Week 2: Understand the Buyer’s Mind

- Interview five recent customers about the moment they decided to buy
- Read twenty competitor reviews and note the recurring complaints
- Write your offer using the buyer’s words, not yours

Week 3: Make the First Impression Count

- Check your homepage loads quickly on a phone
- Rewrite your email preview text for your next send
- Ask someone unfamiliar with your business what they think you do after five seconds

Week 4: Welcome Objections

- Keep a running list of every objection prospects raise
- Turn the top five into FAQ entries
- Add a comparison with the alternative your buyer is most likely considering

Week 5: Believe in It First

- Write one paragraph on why you personally use or trust your product
- Share a behind-the-scenes post about how it is made
- Remove any claim you are not genuinely convinced of

Week 6: Sell Through Service

- Set up a simple welcome sequence for new customers
- A week after each purchase, ask the customer one question: ‘Is it working for you?’
- Make it easy to refer a friend

Week 7: Follow Up

- Write a three-email follow-up for people who showed interest but did not buy
- Set a CRM reminder for every open conversation
- Make unsubscribing one click

Glossary

Discovery call — A conversation with a prospective customer focused on understanding their situation before proposing a solution.

Email sequence — A series of automated emails, sent at set intervals, that keeps in touch with a prospect until they are ready to buy.

FAQ (frequently asked questions) — A section of a page that answers, in advance, the questions buyers most often ask before they purchase.

Founder-led marketing — Marketing in which the founder's own voice, story and expertise are central to the message.

Preview text — The short line an email app shows after the subject line, before the message is opened.

Sources & Notes

The historical passages quoted in this book are reproduced from public domain editions of the following works. Spelling and punctuation are the original authors'; only the typography (dashes and quotation marks) has been modernised.

- *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911)
- Norval A. Hawkins, *Certain Success* (1920)
- William Walker Atkinson, *The Psychology of Salesmanship* (1912)

The modern commentary is editorial. It reflects general practice at the time of writing rather than the results of any single study, and platform rules and consumer-protection law change often and vary by country. Check the current rules where you trade before relying on any legal or regulatory point.

About the Publisher

GetFreeEbooks connects readers and writers around one simple idea: good books should be easy to find and free to read. Browse free, legal ebooks across every genre, join community discussions, and discover new authors — or if you're a writer yourself, connect with readers looking for exactly what you've written.

Connect with GetFreeEbooks.com:

- Website: GetFreeEbooks.com
- Patreon: patreon.com/cw/getfreeebooks
- YouTube: youtube.com/getfreeebooks
- Facebook Page: facebook.com/getfreeebooks
- Facebook Group: facebook.com/groups/getfreebooks
- Instagram: instagram.com/getfreeebooks
- Threads: threads.com/@getfreeebooks
- X / Twitter: twitter.com/getfreeebooks
- Pinterest: pinterest.com/getfreeebooks
- Telegram: t.me/getfree3books
- LinkedIn Group: linkedin.com/groups/4042286
- Reddit: reddit.com/r/GetFreeEbooks
- RSS Feed: getfreeebooks.com/feed

GetFreeEbooks

GetFreeEbooks.com — Download free ebooks, legally. Readers and writers unite.

More Free Ebooks

New ebooks are added regularly — find more free, legally downloadable ebooks across every genre at GetFreeEbooks.com.

Visit our sister site focused on the Internet Marketing niche at GetFreeIMEbooks.com.

Join a community of readers and writers who believe good books should be easy to find.